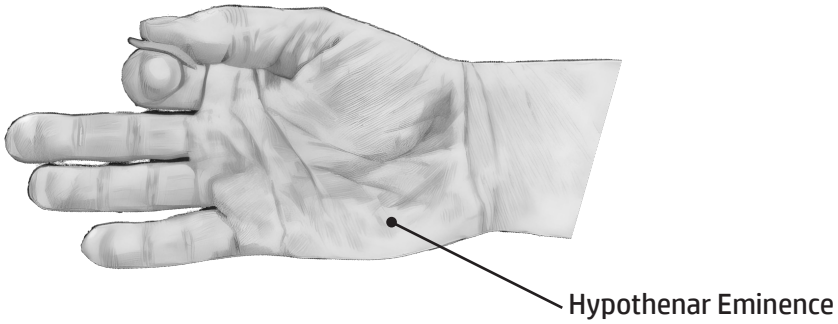
LESSON 6: PALM MUTES

A palm mute is created when the palm of the picking hand rests against the strings while they're being picked/strummed to create a "muffled" sound that works well for unaccented counts. The part of the palm that is used is at the bottom corner of the hand, under the pinkie and near the wrist (anatomically referred to as the hypothenar eminence). It can rest naturally against the strings without impeding small pick movements.

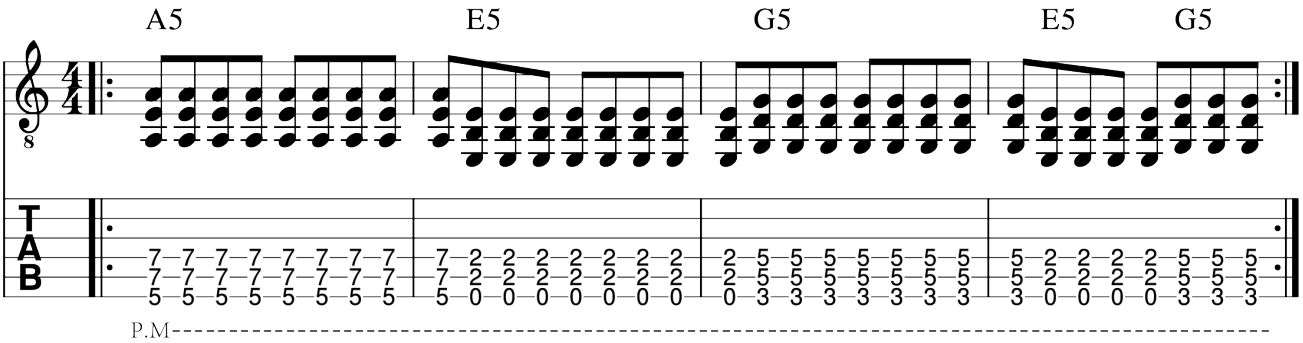


The palm must anchor on the strings near the bridge, close to where the strings end. If the palm is too close to the bridge, the strings may not get muted properly and will ring out too loudly. If it is too far toward on the neck (closer to the fretboard), the mute can be too severe and sound chunky or percussive. Finding the sweet spot on your guitar is vital!

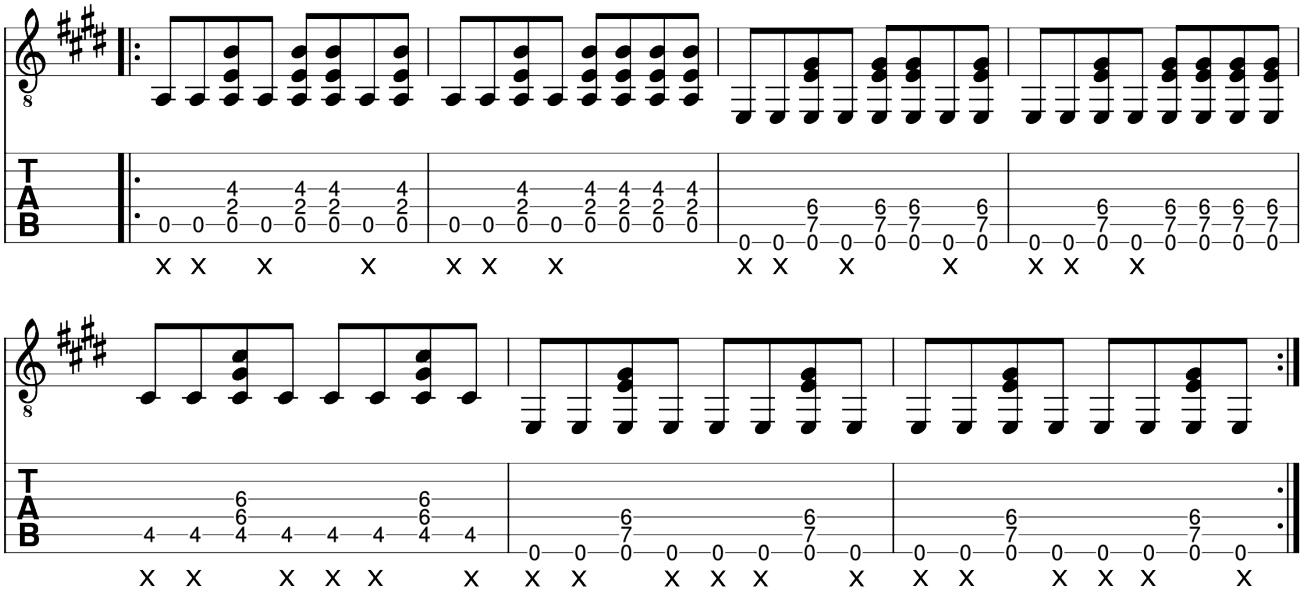
Most palm-mutes occur on just the low-strings. It's hard (if not impossible) to place the palm in a position where it can cover each string and still allow for a strum across all strings.

Exercise

Every note in this exercise is palm muted. The switches mostly occur after the 1 beat. It is a similar progression and style to *"Rolling In the Deep"* by Adele. Palm muted notes are designated with an X symbol, or the letters P.M. beneath the note.



This progression uses palm mutes to create accents in a straight eighth note rhythm. Write in the accents only. It is a similar rhythm to what is hear in *"Everlong"* by Foo Fighters.



Try revisiting older rhythms taught in this book, but use palm mutes for any non-accented counts.

Advice

Try using a slightly thicker pick to help dig into the strings better.

Keep your picking hand in a position where it's quick/easy to apply the palm mute — don't let it stray far!

Try applying some pressure to your palm mute to get a better sound.

Practice this technique on acoustic guitar, but also electric with distortion.

For all exercises in this book, consider replacing the metronome with a drum-machine.